

Chapter

Na Mama — The Power of Surrendering to the Guru



Introduction: The Final Promise of the Gita

Near the very end of the Bhagavad Gita, after eighteen chapters of philosophy, devotion, and instruction, Lord Krishna gives Arjuna what many consider the culmination of the entire teaching:

Sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇaṁ vraja,
ahaṁ tvām sarva-pāpebhyo mokṣayiṣyāmi mā śucaḥ.

"Abandon all dharmas and take refuge in Me alone. I
will liberate you from all sins. Do not grieve."

— Bhagavad Gita 18.66

This single verse holds an entire path. Yet it is also among the most misunderstood verses in the scriptures. What does it mean to "abandon all dharmas"? Who is the "Me" in whom we are to take refuge? And why does surrender bring freedom from sin and sorrow?

In this chapter, we explore these questions through the teachings of Acharya Upendra Ji, who unpacks the verse with remarkable practicality, showing how its promise is meant not only for Arjuna on the battlefield of Kurukshetra, but for every seeker today.

Section 1: Abandon Dharma — Not Adharma

The first thing to notice about this verse is what Krishna does **not** say. He does not say **sarva adharmān parityajya**, "abandon all unrighteousness." Giving up wrongdoing would be an obvious instruction. Instead, He says **sarva-dharmān parityajya**: abandon **all dharmas**.

This is a startling instruction. Throughout the Gita, Krishna has urged Arjuna to fulfil his dharma as a warrior. Why, at the end, would He ask him to give up dharma altogether?

The answer lies in understanding what the word **dharma** truly means.

Section 2: What Dharma Really Means

In everyday speech, **dharma** is often taken to mean religion: Hindu, Muslim, Christian, and so on. But this is not its original sense. As Acharya Upendra Ji explains, **dharma means karma**: not mere activity, but **kartavya-karma**, one's duty-bound action.

Every role we play in life carries its own dharma:

- **Putra-dharma**: the duties of a son or daughter
- **Pitā-dharma**: the duties of a father
- **Pati-dharma**: the duties of a husband
- **Patnī-dharma** or **Pativratā-dharma**: the duties of a wife
- **Paḍosī-dharma**: the duties one owes to a neighbour

In simple terms, dharma is a set of **do's and don'ts**: the things one ought to do and the things one ought not to do in each relationship and circumstance of life.

Seen in this light, Krishna's instruction becomes clear. "Abandon all dharmas" does not mean "become irreligious" or "stop doing your duty." It means: **surrender to Me your entire understanding of what you should and should not do.**

Section 3: Drop Your Own Ideas

Here lies the heart of surrender. Most of us live by our own ideas of right and wrong, built from habit, upbringing, fear, and desire. We decide for ourselves what our duties are and how to fulfil them. And yet our lives remain tangled in problems we cannot seem to solve.

The Gita's prescription is radical in its simplicity: **drop whatever is your idea.** Instead of relying on your own judgement, ask the Guru: **What should I do? What should I not do?**

Acharya Upendra Ji describes the result:

Once the Guru sets the direction, and once you have caught the right direction of karma, the destination will arrive on its own.

This is where surrender meets another famous verse of the Gita:

Karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana.

"Your right is to action alone, never to its fruits."

— Bhagavad Gita 2.47

The seeker's task is to hold firmly to the *saṅkalpa* (the resolve) and keep walking the right path. Showing that path is the Guru's role. When direction is entrusted to the Guru and effort is offered by the disciple, the fruits take care of themselves.

Section 4: The Living Guru — Your Krishna Today

For Arjuna, the one to surrender to was Krishna, standing beside him in the chariot. But who is the "Me" for us?

Acharya Upendra Ji gives a clear and practical answer: **for you, Krishna will be someone else, a living Guru of the present time.**

He explains that a Guru of the future, one who has not yet come, cannot help you. Nor can a Guru of the past, one who has already entered **samādhī**, guide you in the specifics of your daily life. **Only a living Guru, present now, can benefit you.** Only a living Guru can answer your questions, see your situation, and tell you what to do and what not to do.

Arjuna did not surrender to a memory or an idea. He surrendered to a living teacher who could respond to him in the moment. The seeker today needs the same.

Section 5: "I Will Free You From All Sins — Do Not Grieve"

Krishna does not ask for surrender without making a promise in return:

- **Ahaṁ tvāṁ sarva-pāpebhyo mokṣayiṣyāmi:** "I will free you from all sins."
- **Mā śucaḥ:** "Do not grieve. Do not weep."

In effect, the Lord says: **I will clean everything up.**

Why does this matter so much? Because, as Acharya Upendra Ji points out, much of our suffering is rooted in **pāpa** (sinful

or wrong action) and its consequences:

- It is because of sin that **poverty** came.
- It is because of sin that **quarrels** arose.
- It is because of sin that **relationships** were spoiled.

When we are freed from the burden of those sins, the suffering they produced also begins to dissolve. But there is a condition: all this will be set right **if you do as I say**. **Mām ekaṁ śaraṇaṁ vraja**: take refuge in Me alone. The promise belongs to those who truly surrender.

Section 6: Sudden Misfortune and Sudden Healing

Life sometimes brings misfortune suddenly: an illness, a loss, a crisis that seems to come from nowhere. Acharya Upendra Ji explains that such sudden events must be the fruit of some wrong karma performed at some point, whether remembered or not.

But the reverse is also true. Just as suffering can arrive suddenly, **healing can also happen in a single stroke**.

Acharya Upendra Ji refers to a healing that took place during the previous day's session as a living example of this truth.

Section 7: Do Not Bow to Miracles — Bow Properly

Yet when such healing occurs, Acharya Upendra Ji is careful to say: **this is not a miracle**. He offers a memorable teaching that plays on two Hindi words, **chamatkār** (miracle) and **namaskār** (salutation):

Do not offer **namaskār** to **chamatkār**. Do your **namaskār** properly, and the **chamatkār** will happen in your life on its own.

In other words, do not chase miracles or become fascinated with the extraordinary. Instead, learn to bow correctly. When the bowing is genuine, transformation follows naturally.

And what does it mean to bow properly? It means **to drop the ego first**.

Section 8: Na Mama — The True Meaning of Namaskār

Acharya Upendra Ji reveals the deeper meaning hidden within the word **namaskār** itself. At its heart lies the phrase **na mama**: "not mine."

To truly offer **namaskār** is to inwardly declare:

"Not I, but You. Not mine, but Yours."

This is the essence of surrender. It is not a physical gesture of folded hands alone, but an inner shift, a letting go of the sense of "I" and "mine" that keeps us bound.

As this feeling becomes firm and steady in the heart, **the ego departs, and everything begins to fall into place.** This is the real **chamatkār**: not a supernatural event, but the natural consequence of a heart that has stopped clinging and started surrendering.

Summary: Key Takeaways

- 1 **Sarva-dharmān parityajya** means surrendering all of our **kartavya-karma**, our own ideas of duty, not abandoning righteousness.
- 2 **Dharma means duty-bound action**: the do's and don'ts attached to each role in life, such as son, father, husband, wife, and neighbour.
- 3 **Drop your own ideas** of what to do and not do. Ask the Guru, who will set the direction. When the direction is right, the destination comes on its own.
- 4 **For you, Krishna is a living Guru**. Neither a future Guru nor one who has entered samādhi can guide you; only a Guru present now can.
- 5 **Krishna's promise**: "I will free you from all sins; do not grieve." Poverty, quarrels, and broken relationships rooted in sin can be set right through true surrender.
- 6 **Sudden misfortune is the fruit of past wrong karma**, and healing can also happen in a single stroke.
- 7 **Do not bow to miracles**; bow properly, and miracles will follow on their own.

8 Namaskār means **na mama**, "not mine." "Not I, but You; not mine, but Yours." As this feeling strengthens, the ego dissolves and life is set right.